Your Honor, He's Cute

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Your Honor, He’s Cute

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Two rival attorneys. One defamation case. Zero emotional awareness. Mydei is just trying to protect a journalist, win his motions, and not strangle Phainon in open court. Phainon is just trying to ask him out without spontaneously combusting. (Spoiler: he combusts.)

Notes

Oh yeah PS, I kinda shot myself in the foot with this, but Stratton and Straton are different. The one with two t is the firm, while the one with one t is the last name. It’s not really a big deal but I’m saying this in case any of the more detail oriented ppl get confused.

Also, since I know some people think it’s a bit in the ehhh territory to involve irl cases and stuff, I changed the cases into something fictional I made up so no need worry abt that, and for my people who DO like it, if u really want you can try to guess which case(s) they were based on since yeah I had to do some research to pull some Inspo👍

Or you guys could just read it normally for the romance which yeah, probably the easier thing to do😭

(This au was rec by a reader and I just went down from here😍)

See the end of the work for more notes

The courthouse always felt half-dead at this hour.

Fluorescent lights buzzed faintly overhead, humming against marble floors and state-issued furniture. Someone must've run the polish too aggressively last night—each step Mydei took echoed back at him. The air held a crisp chill that hadn't been warmed by bodies yet, and the distant click of heels or shifting paper did little to make the place feel inhabited. Courtroom 2B sat at the end of the long corridor, its door already unlocked. A draft slipped under it like a whisper.

Inside, the lights were on. Everything else was still.

And there, dead center on the defense table, sat the now-expected disruption: a single paper coffee cup, lidless and smug, with a post-it stuck to its side. The yellow note looked almost cheerful in contrast to the solemnity of the courtroom—like it didn't quite belong in a space designed for public dissection of lives and legislation.

Don't kill anyone. (Except metaphorically.) – P.

The smiley face drawn beneath it was crooked, like always. Mydei stood in the doorway for a moment, staring at it like it might vanish if he willed it hard enough. It didn't. It never did.

He didn't sigh. Didn't smile. Just stepped inside, pulled the coffee off the table like it had offended him personally, and took a long sip. The taste was precisely how he liked it: warm but not scalding, cinnamon dusted over oat milk foam, a whisper of sweetness. A perfect cup. Of course it was.

"Creep," he muttered into the rim.

This had been going on for years now. Since they started clashing over courtrooms and clients and column headlines. Since Phainon had started showing up like some slick, sharp-eyed calamity on the other side of every case Mydei touched. High-profile litigation. Political scandals. Public trust lawsuits. Their names had become fixtures on opposing paperwork, the kind that made reporters grin and interns place bets.

And without fail, every trial morning, the coffee would be there. Like clockwork. Like a ritual.

No explanation. No note left behind except the one glued to the cup. Usually no acknowledgement from Phainon himself, who always breezed into the courtroom ten minutes later with some casual, insufferable remark about the weather or Mydei's tie. Never once mentioning the coffee (Unless he meant to tease).

He knows. Of course he does. He knows exactly which mornings Mydei drinks it and which he doesn't. He probably keeps score.

The staff once asked if they were dating. He hasn't recovered from the memory of that question.

Mydei took another sip. The courtroom, spotless, suddenly felt a little too aware of him.

It was going to be a long morning.

The trial was still in pre-witness phase, but the press had already devoured it like meat. A defamation suit between one of the country's most recognizable tech CEOs and an investigative journalist from a rapidly growing independent outlet. The stakes were high enough to command national attention—stock market fluctuations, freedom of the press arguments, buried whistleblower testimony. And, of course, the fact that both attorneys at the center of it seemed to hate each other in a way that read like romantic tragedy if you tilted your head.

Mydei's firm, Kremnos Stratton, had taken the journalist's side. Fiercely. He'd been handed the file less than a day after the article went live. It was the kind of piece that named names and dates, the kind that came with internal documents and a nervous source or two in the margins. The CEO, predictably, had filed suit within the week. Defamation. Reputational harm. Market loss. "Irreparable brand damage," whatever that meant.

Phainon, naturally, represented the plaintiff. His firm—Okhema Vale—was the sort of glass-tower institution that boasted clients with islands. It made

perfect sense. They liked flashy. They liked aggressive. And they liked Phainon.

That part still puzzled people: how the hell he and Mydei ended up across the courtroom from each other so often, how their cases kept colliding, overlapping, circling until it became almost expected. What no one realized—not even the partners, probably—was that it wasn't coincidence. It was choice.

Whenever Phainon's name came up on a filing, Mydei said yes. Automatically. Recklessly. And when Mydei's name made it into discovery logs or media mentions, Phainon had a habit of showing up whether he'd been invited or not. The coffee thing was just an extension of that. Phainon was always early enough to leave it, somehow, even if they weren't assigned the same courtroom until the night before. He probably had someone on internal scheduling. Or worse, he just guessed and got it right.

It was ridiculous.

It was also… reliable.

Mydei set the cup down, fingers curling against the cardboard sleeve. The hearing today was procedural—discovery disputes, third-party subpoenas, a request for protective order over the source's identity. Nothing explosive. But still, cameras were likely. Tech blogs had set up newsletters to track the case. Even the New York Times had run an op-ed last week, framing it as a watershed moment for modern press freedom.

And somehow, in the middle of all that noise, *he* was standing here and in a few minutes, across from Phainon. Again.

Mydei glanced at the empty chairs, the polished witness box, the heavy wood doors still closed to the public.

It was going to be an even longer trial.

He slid into his seat at the defense table, laptop already thrumming from where he'd flipped it open. The heat had dulled, but the flavor lingered,

cinnamon forward. His jaw ticked.

Focus.

He set the cup aside and brought up the folder he'd prepped the night before —**Straton v. Letois Media, et al**.. Tabs stacked the bottom of his screen: *Exhibits, Motions in Limine, Outline – Procedural 4/11, Affidavit Source Timeline.*

He worked methodically, just as he always did. The case had already gone through three preliminary hearings, two rounds of media-induced chaos, and one failed settlement push. They were nowhere near done.

On the laptop: exhibits preloaded—PDFs of internal memos, timestamped threads that aligned too neatly with project cancellations, and screenshots of the CEO's press statements that contradicted sworn testimony.

In his binder, everything else. Annotated exhibits. Color-coded flags for quick objection points. A printout of the hearing outline with procedural arguments circled in pencil, margin-noted with reference caselaw. Protective order motion: *Start with Radnor v. Ellis, then pivot to Hanley v. State.* Emphasize public interest angle. His handwriting was small, clean, painfully efficient.

He thumbed through the pages, scanning for anything he'd missed. The press would call today boring—no witness fireworks, no smoking gun—but that was fine. Let them nap through it. This was where cases were won.

He paused halfway through the hearing outline.

There, nestled between two paper-clipped pages, was a post-it. Not his.

Page 7: Excellent point. I'm stealing it. – P.

The handwriting was slanted, tilted forward. A little messy. The smiley face at the end was smaller this time. Mydei stared at it for a moment, as if the ink might rearrange itself into something less infuriating, then plucked it out without a word. Crumpled it. Shoved it in the outer folder pocket.

He didn’t ask how Phainon got into his materials. He never did. And Phainon never explained.

The worst part? Page 7 did have an excellent point. It was the part about balancing public interest against reputational harm, cited from a fairly obscure Ninth Circuit decision. A strong anchor for their motion to quash the subpoena against the anonymous source.

Mydei made a small mark in the margin anyway. Highlighted the line Phainon would probably latch onto when it was his turn to argue.

He reached for the folder marked **PHAINON – WILD CARDS.**

It was his own invention. A slim, navy folder with three tabs: *Motions They Might Try, Last-Minute Evidence Dumps, Quotes from Prior Arguments.* He flipped through it quickly. Phainon had a pattern—he liked citing off-circuit cases with flair, particularly anything that read like it belonged in a law school final. The more dramatic the footnote, the better.

Mydei had counterpoints ready. He always did.

There was a plan, as always. Lead with their motion to protect the source identity—invoke journalistic privilege, argue undue burden. Shift next into the motion to compel further financial disclosure from the CEO—challenge the alleged “market loss” with actual valuation reports from weeks before the article ever published. End with narrowing the scope of what could be discussed in trial—limit emotional appeal, keep it simple strictly fact-based. Evidence first. Don’t let them *breathe*.

Phainon would hate that.

He double-checked his exhibit list. Then the hearing outline again. He adjusted the angle of his screen.

For a moment, the only sound in the courtroom was the subtle flick of pages and the distant rattle of a rolling cart out in the hallway.

Then—footsteps.

Louder than the others. Familiar, even.

The door creaked open. Mydei didn’t look up.

But he knew. By the rhythm of those goddamn shoes, he knew exactly who it was.

Phainon walked in with ease, looking as though he hadn’t a care in the world.

And, just like every time, Mydei’s jaw locked. His grip tightened on the coffee cup he’d already finished.

He did not look. Not yet.

He had a hearing to win.

Phainon slid into his seat across the aisle—plaintiff’s side, nearest the bench. His briefcase hit the floor with a soft thud. No laptop, as usual. Just that damn legal pad again already half-scrawled with notes in that slanted handwriting Mydei found obnoxiously messy. He wore a navy tie today, a subtle one, knotted neat at the collar but loosened just enough to look like he’d had a real morning.

He looked up, met Mydei’s eye for all of two seconds.

Then: “That coffee disappear on its own, or do I get credit this time?”

Mydei didn’t answer. He clicked his pen once. Loudly.

Phainon smiled, small and not at all smug. “You muttered something when you drank it. I wasn’t close enough to catch it, but I’m assuming it was a heartfelt thank you.”

“It was ‘creep,’” Mydei said.

Phainon’s brow lifted. “You’re getting sentimental.”

“Keep telling yourself that.”

The courtroom hadn’t filled in yet—just a few quiet shuffles behind them as the gallery settled, the muted rustle of papers and the soft ping of someone’s phone being silenced. Still, it was enough to dull the edge of their words. They didn’t have to whisper. But there was a hush to the room anyway, like they were two people leaning too close to a fireplace.

Phainon rested his elbow on the arm of his chair, leaning slightly.

“I liked your motion,” he said, casually. “The source protection argument. You found a way to thread the public interest needle without overreaching.”

Mydei glanced over. “Was that a compliment?”

“I’m not above giving credit,” Phainon said. “Even when it’s inconvenient.”

“Mm.” Mydei flipped a page in his binder. “I’m sure your rebuttal will be just as generous.”

“I’m sure it won’t be,” Phainon said, voice lighter. “But it’ll be fair. That counts for something.”

He wasn’t posturing. That was the annoying part. Mydei had spent years facing down attorneys who bluffed and barked and flexed their credentials like armor. Phainon wasn’t like that. He didn’t puff up. He didn’t play power games.

He just *meant* it—whatever ‘it’ happened to be.

That made him harder to hate.

Which made him worse.

Mydei shut the binder wordlessly. “You’re not stealing page seven.”

Phainon tilted his head. “You saw that?”

Mydei just stared. Phainon held up both hands in mock surrender.

“Fine. I’ll paraphrase.”

Before Mydei could reply, the heavy side door groaned open.

The judge stepped in, trailed by a clerk who deposited a folder onto the bench. The courtroom snapped into order—attorneys straightening, the gallery rustling into silence, a deputy clearing his throat near the door.

“All rise.”

The procedural hearing had begun.

Judge leaned into the mic with a dry, practiced cadence. “Be seated.”

Chairs scuffed softly against tile. Phainon adjusted his legal pad, flipping to a fresh page with the edge of his thumb. Mydei clicked his pen once, then set it down beside the binder.

The judge skimmed a few pages of the docket folder, then glanced up.

“All right,” she said, gaze shifting from one table to the other. “Straton versus Letois Media, et al.—scheduled procedural hearing on pre-trial motions. We’ll address outstanding discovery limitations, the source protection request, financial disclosures, and any lingering scope disputes.”

A pause.

“I trust counsel are prepared.”

Phainon’s voice came first, clear and without hesitation. “We are, Your Honor.”

Then Mydei: “We are.”

The judge nodded, flipping open her notepad. “Then let’s begin with the defense’s motion to quash the subpoena targeting the anonymous source referenced in the February article. Counsel?”

Mydei stood.

The scrape of his chair was muted. He didn’t glance at the gallery. Instead, he reached for the folder marked EXHIBITS – PROTECTIVE ORDER and handed a copy to the clerk.

“Our motion to quash is rooted in well-established protections surrounding source confidentiality,” he said. “The journalist in question—Mr. Damaris—not only cited a credible informant within Kallistrate Technologies, but corroborated the claims with timestamped internal memos and correspondence. Forcing disclosure of that source would not only chill future whistleblower cooperation but directly undercut the public’s interest in exposing corporate misconduct.”

He paused, just long enough for the words to settle.

“We begin with Radnor v. Ellis, Ninth Circuit, which upheld source privilege even under significant reputational stakes. In that case, the court held that speculative harm could not override the concrete value of investigative transparency. And while plaintiff’s counsel may attempt to distinguish this case based on corporate stature or shareholder volatility, we maintain that the standard applies. Public interest outweighs potential embarrassment—especially when evidence supports the reporting.”

He flipped the page, pencil already in hand. “We also note Hanley v. State, where the burden of disclosure was deemed undue due to lack of narrowly tailored necessity. We argue the same here. The plaintiff’s case does not hinge on knowing the source’s name—it hinges on disproving the article’s accuracy. That’s a different standard.”

The judge gave a slow nod, turning slightly toward Phainon. “Response?”

Phainon rose calmly. Seems like he had his lines memorized to heart.

“Your Honor, we’re not asking the court to unilaterally pierce privilege,” he said. “But we are asking it to consider proportionality. Our client, Mr. Straton, asserts that key allegations in the article—allegations which materially affected Kallistrate’s stock valuation—are tied to statements made by an unnamed insider. That insider’s credibility matters. Their access, their motives, whether they even existed.”

He held up a page—just a printed statement already in the record. “We’ve provided direct contradictions between the article and verifiable timelines. Without the source’s identity, we’re forced to disprove shadows. That isn’t due process—it’s obfuscation.”

He glanced once—briefly—across the aisle, not quite smiling.

“But I’ll concede one thing: opposing counsel’s needle-threading was elegant.”

Mydei did not react. But he underlined a note in the margin.

Phainon added, “We ask the court to consider limited in-camera review, sealed if necessary, to assess the source’s credibility without full disclosure. This isn’t a fishing expedition. It’s about whether the foundation of a damning article can bear the weight it’s been given.”

The judge scratched a few notes. “Understood. I’ll rule after review of supplemental materials from both parties by end of week.”

Mydei sat. So did Phainon.

Silence, for a moment.

Then the judge lifted the next folder. “Let’s proceed to the motion to compel financial disclosures from Mr. Straton’s firm. Defense?”

Mydei was already flipping tabs.

The rest of the hearing blurred into controlled chaos—nothing explosive, but everything urgent.

Arguments volleyed back and forth: scope restrictions, language in the jury instructions, a third-party subpoena to an analytics firm that tracked fallout from the article. Phainon brought up a Sixth Circuit decision Mydei hadn’t flagged. It wasn’t irrelevant, but it wasn’t persuasive either—just flashy enough to make the judge scribble a note.

He hated how often that happened.

They spent twenty minutes on financial disclosures alone. Mydei pushed for updated valuation reports—ones from before the article dropped, not after. Phainon didn't object to the premise, only the scope.

"Defense wants a forensic sweep of five years of investor reports," he said, dry. "We'd rather not treat discovery like a hostile audit."

The judge smirked at that. Just barely. Mydei didn't.

By the second hour, the courtroom lights had begun to feel too sterile, too white. Someone in the gallery sneezed and no one blessed them. The only warmth came from the quiet friction of objection and reply, rebuttal and reply-to-the-rebuttal.

Mydei was still flipping between his notes when the judge finally capped her pen.

"We'll take a short recess," she said. "Back in fifteen."

Chairs scraped. The gallery stirred. One of the plaintiff's junior associates bolted for the hallway like recess in middle school. Mydei didn't move.

Phainon, of course, did.

He crossed the aisle with a paper cup in hand—his own this time, not a peace offering—and leaned just far enough over the rail to draw Mydei's glare without technically violating the space.

"You want the case law cite from earlier?" he asked. "I figured you'd want to scrawl something snarky in the margin."

Mydei didn't look up. "I already did. Under 'irrelevant but dramatic.'"

"Hmm." Phainon tapped the lid of his cup thoughtfully. "Maybe I'll add that to my next motion. Title it 'Theatrical Exhibits,' just for you."

"Don't flatter yourself. You're not that entertaining."

"That's not what your notes said on page seven."

Mydei snapped his binder shut.

Phainon grinned—not triumphantly, more so as if genuinely enjoying the banter.

A deputy cleared his throat, and Phainon took the hint, stepping back toward his side of the room. Mydei stayed seated, eyes fixed on the center of the bench, as if sheer concentration could vaporize the last ten minutes from existence.

Fifteen minutes passed in a blur of hallway echoes and distant footsteps.

When they reconvened, the rhythm resumed. Tighter now. Arguments compressed. Deadlines confirmed. The judge moved briskly through the remainder of the docket, declining to rule on a handful of motions until briefs could be reviewed.

At 4:36 p.m., she closed the file and nodded once.

“Court is adjourned.”

The gavel didn’t slam. It just tapped, once.

Mydei didn’t relax, but he started packing up.

Across the aisle, Phainon was already folding his legal pad closed, that same navy tie still just slightly askew now.

Mydei hated that.

He also… didn’t.

Not that it mattered. Not yet.

Not until the next round.

Which, if he knew anything about Phainon, wouldn’t take long to arrive.

Phainon looked up as Mydei slid the last tab into place in his folder. That half-smile again—subtle, anchored by something he couldn't name. He gave a nod across the aisle. It wasn't serious, but still felt relevant somehow.

Mydei didn't return it.

He slung his bag over one shoulder, offered the clerk a word about upcoming filing deadlines, and walked out without waiting for anything more.

There was no firm message pinged his phone. No summons from a partner. No emergency motions. The judge had deferred rulings to briefs. Discovery held. For the first time in weeks, the pressure relented.

Still, he didn't go home. Didn't grab lunch. Didn't even think about calling it early.

Instead, he cut past the elevators and followed the long hallway to the courthouse library. A quiet detour. Not unusual—but not exactly restful either.

He found a seat near the back wall, a corner table marked with old scuffs and faded numbers etched by bored interns. Binder open, laptop booted. The folder marked WILD CARDS fanned beside it. He worked through reference caselaw for the source protection motion, cross-checked citations, flagged a few rulings from the Sixth Circuit. Somewhere along the way he forgot to blink.

Fifteen minutes passed like that. Focused, but taut. The kind of focus that came from tension, not clarity.

Then a voice broke the quiet:

"You too? Didn't peg you for a library type this late."

He didn't look up.

Phainon came around the far end of the nearest shelf with a paperback tucked beneath one arm. Not even legal. Something slim and yellowed, dog-eared at the corner.

He glanced at Mydei like the whole thing was incidental—an accident of timing, like just a few minutes prior they weren't at each other's necks. If he felt out of place, he didn't show it.

"Long day?" he asked.

What do you think?

Mydei turned a page without answering.

Phainon set the book down and took the chair across from him. The paperback stayed closed in his lap.

"You're not here to work," Mydei said.

"I like the quiet."

Mydei scoffed under his breath. "Since when?"

"Since about five minutes ago."

His tone wasn't sharp, but it wasn't soft either. Mydei leaned back in his chair, arms folded, and gave him a look that didn't bother hiding the suspicion behind it.

"If this is about that post-it note—"

"It isn't."

"You're a terrible liar."

Phainon let that pass.

Mydei shifted his weight and glanced down at the open folder in front of him. He didn't want to ask, but the question pressed its way forward

anyway.

“You filed that source challenge early. Got it on record before our motion could lead. That wasn’t an accident.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed slightly, but his reply didn’t come with heat. “It was timing. Not sabotage.”

“Right.”

“Come on,” Phainon said, quieter now. “You’ve read enough of my work to know I don’t play it that cheap.”

Mydei didn’t answer. His eyes dropped to the table. For a moment, the quiet stretched too far.

Then Phainon spoke again—carefully.

“I’ve seen you like this before.”

Mydei frowned.

“When things build up,” Phainon added. “You get rattled instead of rest.”

It wasn’t an accusation exactly. It was true in a way Mydei didn’t want it to be.

“I’m not your little case study,” he muttered.

“I didn’t say you were.”

“Don’t act like you know how I work.”

Phainon leaned back slightly, arms relaxed, gaze steady. “But I do.”

Mydei stared at him. For a second, everything stalled.

Then he stood up, quick and practiced, and packed the folder away like it was something he needed to be rid of.

“I’ve got what I came for.”

Phainon didn’t argue. He didn’t offer some breezy quip or try to keep him there.

As Mydei turned to leave, Phainon just reached for his book again—thumb sliding to the folded page—and said, almost offhandedly:

“You never throw the post-its out. You just hide them behind your monitor.”

Mydei didn’t give him the satisfaction of a response.

He walked out without looking back.

The partners at Kremnos Stratton called it an “optics review,” which really just meant: how bad did it look on camera when you lost a motion you technically should’ve won.

Mydei sat at the head of the internal conference table while two associates loaded screen captures of media coverage onto the display. He kept his expression neutral. Just… disengaged enough to read as competent and controlled.

One tab showed a split screen—Phainon mid-sentence at the plaintiff’s podium, one hand half raised like he was teaching a class. Mydei in the other frame, seated, arms crossed, not even blinking. The chyron below read: **STRATON v. LETOIS – DEFAMATION HEARING HEATS UP.**

Hephaestion leaned in from the seat beside him, voice pitched low. “You look like you’re about to commit a war crime.”

“Didn’t.”

“You still could,” he offered, encouragingly.

Mydei shifted the binder in front of him. “Why are we even doing this? The judge deferred rulings. There was no loss.”

“The press doesn’t see nuance,” the senior partner said without looking up from her tablet. “They see footage. We look reactive. Especially with you not countering his closing framing.”

“Because it wasn’t a closing,” Mydei muttered. “It was a procedural hearing.”

“That’s not how it read to viewers.”

He swallowed his sigh. Said nothing.

Ten more minutes of dissection. Mydei took mental notes only for the sake of later case prep, not for whatever this performance review passed as. When they were finally dismissed, he didn’t stand. He just pinched the bridge of his nose and stayed seated until the door closed behind the last associate.

Hephaestion, loyal bastard that he was, remained in his seat. And true to form, waited a beat before whispering, “How bad do *you* think it looked?”

Mydei groaned into his palm. “Please don’t.”

“Because, like, if I were a juror watching from home, I’d think you two were—”

“Say ‘star-crossed’ and I’ll unwrite your hours.”

Hephaestion snorted. “Fine. I’ll behave. But hey—”

He straightened slightly. Mydei side-eyed him, not liking the tone already forming in the back of his throat.

“—white hair went to your office earlier.”

Mydei blinked. “What.”

“He let himself in like we were hosting open house.”

“And you’re telling me this now?”

Hephaestion shrugged. “Wasn’t sure if it was a threat or a… gesture. Figured you’d know.”

Mydei stood.

He didn’t speak or even grab his things. Instead, he exited the conference room with a pace that was far too calm to be normal. Hephaestion followed, several steps behind, knowing what came next wouldn’t be boring.

Mydei reached his office, turned the handle, and pushed the door open with enough intent to qualify as *legal* grounds for confrontation. He was already framing the sentence in his mind—get out, I’ll call security—when the words stalled somewhere behind his teeth.

There was no Phainon.

Just a bouquet.

On his desk.

A clear-glass vase. Roses. Deep, glossy red.

A single yellow sticky note leaned against the base.

Mydei stared.

Behind him, Hephaestion stepped inside and whistled, soft and judgmental.

“They’re flowers,” he offered, unhelpfully.

“I can see that.”

“They’re *roses*.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “Too obvious.”

“Too—?”

Hephaestion tilted his head.

Mydei stepped closer, careful not to touch the vase. He studied the petals, the way the light caught on the darker edges.

“Symbolic,” he muttered. “Blood-red. Intimidation tactic. Possibly a reference to the article’s title. Could be threatening tone disguised as charm. Meant to rattle.”

Hephaestion dropped his head into his hands.

“Mydeimos,” he said, muffled. “They’re not a hostage negotiation. They’re *romantic*.”

Mydei looked at him like *he* had just committed a crime.

“Are you feeling alright?”

“I’m fine. But you are *deeply* unwell.”

Mydei tapped the sticky note with one finger. He didn’t flip it over. Not yet. Just stood there, brow drawn like he was waiting for the flowers to confess to something.

Hephaestion sighed. Loudly. “I’m going back to work before you accuse the daisies of corporate espionage.”

“These are roses.”

“Exactly my point.”

Hephaestion left. Mydei stayed.

And the roses didn’t move.

The note stayed in his drawer.

He didn’t read It. It was already there—filed, categorized, mentally indexed alongside every other time Phainon had said *good job* without saying it outright.

He decided to work on the outline. Adjusted phrasing on a section about source protection precedent. Re-flagged a statute that might conflict with the court's interpretation. Drafted the header of a memo that wouldn't be due for another week, then deleted it and started again, this time tightening the focus.

The hours moved cleanly. That helped. Precision had always been the best antidote to ambiguity.

Eventually, though, the edge of his focus drifted. A rhythm in his thoughts broke, just slightly. Enough that his hands slowed. Enough that he opened a new tab.

He typed in Phainon's name.

Strategic, not personal. If Okhema Vale intended to make this case a media fixture, it made sense to track how they positioned themselves—what their attorneys shared, reposted, ignored. Any information could be useful later.

That was the reason why. Definitely.

Phainon's profile came up fast. Open, visible, too casually curated to be accidental. The top post was a photo from earlier that week. He wasn't tagged as the uploader, but it had his mark all over it. He stood in front of a coffee cart with Castorice and Aglaea, shoulder-to-shoulder, arms casually slung. Castorice's expression was polite, a rare hint of amusement tucked at the corner of her mouth. Aglea held her coffee like she was weighing a verdict.

Phainon was mid-laugh.

The image wasn't posed. His clothing was askew, his teeth visible, his hair curled slightly at the edges where it always unraveled by late afternoon.

Mydei stared longer than he meant to.

He hadn't even realized he'd leaned closer, until his hand shifted on the desk and brushed the trackpad. The screen jumped. A heart icon lit red at

the bottom corner of the post.

He froze.

The cursor hovered.

He clicked it again. The red disappeared.

Nothing else moved. No alarms sounded. No notifications. The post reset, like it hadn’t happened at all.

His chest still felt tight.

He shut the tab. Closed the browser. Re-centered the laptop in front of him as if it had slipped.

It was irrelevant. A distraction. There were better uses of time.

He pulled open a draft to track the next filing deadline and forced his attention forward.

But even with his eyes on the page, some part of him hadn’t quite moved on. A thread tugged as he was reminded of something back to the early days—law school, first year, first debate. A crowded auditorium. Harsh lights. That voice, fast and sure and aggravatingly clear. He remembered the first time they’d locked eyes across the stage, how quickly that had become habit.

They’d been neck-and-neck on everything—grades, clerkships, rankings, competitions. Even the professors had known it. You couldn’t say one name without the other.

And then there was that night.

The one they both ignored whenever it tried to surface.

It didn’t matter. Not now.

He adjusted the document’s font style back to his usual. Closed the drawer with the note. Opened a new tab and pulled up the court’s docket schedule.

He had work to do.

The light through the blinds was grey and uninspired—the kind of early morning hue that didn’t wake you so much as nudge at your skull until the headache bloomed.

Mydei shifted, slowly, the dull ache in his neck spreading down to his shoulders. The office chair had long lost any pretense of comfort, and the stack of printouts under his arm hadn’t made for a worthy pillow. One leg was still half-hooked around his desk, the other braced against the carpet. He blinked up at the ceiling for a long moment, disoriented.

The knock came after. Not loud. Enough to suggest the person on the other side had already seen through the glass pane and was pretending not to.

Peucesta stepped in without waiting.

He looked freshly pressed and far too awake, tie neat and mug in hand. His gaze swept once over the room, then landed—not on Mydei—but on the bouquet.

He didn’t speak. Not immediately. Just gave Mydei a sympathetic glance that somehow managed to avoid being pitying. His eyes lingered on the flowers, then flicked back to Mydei, question hovering without form.

Mydei sat up with a low wince, cracking his neck. “Don’t.”

Peucesta raised his brows. “Didn’t say anything.”

“You didn’t have to.”

A pause stretched. Muted morning sounds filtered in from the hallway—footsteps, the elevator’s distant chime, a printer spitting out some memo that would no doubt be ignored. Peucesta walked over and handed Mydei

the second coffee he'd been holding, then leaned against the wall, gaze still tracking the desk.

"You left your office light on," he said. "Figured you were here. Though I was far from the only one."

Mydei took a long sip, letting the heat work its way past the dull throb in his temples. "The only one with a key?"

"No, but probably the only one who wouldn't take a picture first."

Mydei stopped mid-sip.

Peucesta kept his voice mild. "It's just… the whole floor saw the delivery. And then saw you didn't leave. The story sort of filled itself in."

Mydei stared at him. Peucesta held the gaze, calm as ever. Then, mercifully, looked away again.

Mydei set the mug down and rubbed his eyes. "Don't say it."

"I won't."

"But you're thinking it."

Peucesta glanced back toward the flowers. "They are… elaborate."

Mydei groaned once, full-bodied, into his hands. "Did you come here to witness the collapse of my dignity or—?"

"Just to wake you up before the partners found you," Peucesta said. "Figured you'd rather hear it from me than have someone else knock with a headline already drafted."

Mydei muttered a thank you, mostly into the back of his wrist.

Peucesta took it in stride. "So…" he started, then caught himself, hesitated. His gaze flicked once more to the bouquet. "No card?"

“There was a note,” Mydei said flatly.

Peucesta didn’t ask what it said.

Mydei sighed, rolling his shoulders as he reached for his laptop. “I’ll be functional in ten. Maybe fifteen.”

Peucesta nodded, lingering a moment longer. “Try not to fall in love with your opposition before closing arguments.”

“I said don’t.”

“Right. I didn’t say anything.”

He left before Mydei could find a folder to throw.

Mydei hadn’t intended to leave the building.

But after two hours of trying—and failing—to draft a memo with one eye twitching at the corner of every email, he gave up. Grabbed his coat. Didn’t tell anyone where he was going. Just walked until the air stopped tasting like recycled carpet and manufactured tension.

The bakery he ended up in wasn’t anything special. A narrow corner shop with fogged glass and too many emotionally constipated people, teenagers and adults alike. He ordered the first thing with sugar on top and sat at a two-top with one crooked leg.

It was peaceful.

He took one bite.

And then someone collided into him, shoulder to chest. His pastry gave a dramatic, airborne spiral, narrowly missed a passing stroller, and landed with a wet splat against the ground.

Mydei froze, hand still half-raised. He looked up.

Of course.

White hair. Blue jacket. Slightly confused expression, followed by immediate recognition and what could only be described as a stupid wave.

Phainon.

Mydei stared at him like the laws of physics had failed. Which, arguably, they had.

Phainon blinked. “Hi.”

Mydei did not respond. He was two seconds away from launching himself across the tile—whether it was for the roses, the library, or the fact that he was now pastryless remained unclear, even to him. Only the thought of legal repercussions kept him from committing a misdemeanor.

Phainon glanced toward the crime scene of frosting and jam. “That had a lot of layers. I’m sorry.”

Mydei was still processing rage.

“And, uh,” Phainon added, almost sheepishly, “I didn’t mean to interrupt your snack-based coping mechanism. You always were a sugar gremlin under stress.”

Mydei blinked once. Very slowly.

Phainon winced. “Right. That one wasn’t meant to be out loud.”

Mydei breathed in, sharp through his nose. “You’re buying me a new one.”

Phainon nodded, already stepping toward the counter. “Of course. I’ll get the—what was it? Raspberry custard chaos…something?”

Mydei followed a beat behind, grim and betrayed. “If they’re out, I’m pressing charges.”

They ended up at one of the small tables outside, the air warm enough to justify staying out a little longer. Mydei didn’t say much. He unwrapped the pastry Phainon had bought to replace the one he’d knocked to the sidewalk, leaned back in his chair, and started eating like it was the first calm moment he’d had all day.

Phainon watched him for a beat longer than necessary, then looked down at his own drink, letting the quiet stretch.

“You skipped out,” Mydei said eventually, without looking up.

“So did you.”

“I earned it.”

“Didn’t say you didn’t.”

Mydei tore off another bite with slow precision. Phainon resisted the urge to smile, just barely.

“I was under the impression you couldn’t be lured out of the office for anything short of fire code violations,” Mydei added.

“Castorice sent me. She threatened to get Aglaea involved.”

“Reasonable fear.”

“Terrifying, actually.”

That got something—barely a twitch of Mydei’s mouth. Not a smile. But close enough that Phainon let himself look at him again, a little longer this time. He rarely got to see him like this—shoulders not squared, expression not tightened for court, no press around to perform for. Just the smallest pause in a long week. And still cutting as ever, even if he didn’t know how to sit still unless something was on fire.

“Did you sleep at all?” Phainon asked.

Mydei gave a noncommittal shrug. “Some.”

“That’s not a no.”

“That’s also not your business.”

Phainon let that one pass.

The silence came back—easier this time. Mydei finished the last of the pastry and brushed a crumb from his tie, eyes flicking once across the street like he was already halfway back to work. But he hadn’t moved yet. That counted for something.

Phainon set his cup down. “I can walk you back.”

Mydei gave him a look, unreadable as ever. “Since when do you walk me anywhere?”

“Since I knocked your snack near traffic.”

“You bought a new one.”

“And I still feel guilty.”

Mydei didn’t argue, but his expression shifted. Phainon didn’t press. He stood slowly, waiting.

After a beat, Mydei followed. No protest, no thanks. But he didn’t walk ahead either. They fell into step, side by side, without a word. And Phainon tried not to let it show just how much that alone was enough to undo him.

Mydei didn’t think much of it, at first.

Phainon kept pace beside him, hands in his pockets like this was some kind of errand instead of the accidental walk it had turned into. Mydei didn’t ask why he was still there. He didn’t really care. The weather was decent, the pastry had been good, and he was full enough now that the edge of his usual urgency had dulled to something manageable.

He hummed, faint and tuneless. Nothing dramatic. Just a quiet habit, barely audible.

Phainon glanced over. “Is that new?”

“What?”

“The humming.”

Mydei raised a brow. “You’ve walked me home before?”

“Once,” Phainon said. “That night after the fundraiser. You were drunk off Prosecco and told me you could recite the entire Emperion Constitution.”

“I could.”

“You passed out before the preamble.”

Mydei didn’t dignify that with a response.

They rounded a corner near the edge of the district, and the silhouette of the firm appeared through the clustered buildings ahead. Fifteen more minutes, maybe less. Mydei didn’t bother checking the time. For once, it didn’t feel like anything was on fire.

Phainon cleared his throat. “Are you free next week?”

Mydei frowned, side-eyeing him. “No.”

Phainon blinked. “You didn’t even check your calendar.”

“I already know. I’ve got filings due Monday, witness reviews on Wednesday, and Stratton’s dragging me into prep meetings whether I want to be there or not. Why?”

There was a beat of silence.

Phainon coughed lightly. “No reason.”

“Right.”

But he kept walking.

Another block passed. They didn’t speak. Mydei assumed Phainon had gotten whatever answer he needed.

Then, softly: “What about after that? The week after?”

“Still working.”

“Even Friday?”

“Yes.”

Another pause. Mydei narrowed his eyes. “Why do you keep asking?”

Phainon’s reply took a beat too long. “Just thought it might be good to talk. Just us.”

Mydei’s steps slowed just a fraction. “Is this a trick?”

Phainon looked at him. “What?”

“You’re working for Okhema Vale. I’m opposing counsel. You want to talk? About what, settlement angles? A strategic confession? Are you trying to get me to relax so you can blindside me again in court?”

Phainon gave a short exhale—not quite a sigh. “That’s not what this is.”

“Then what is it?”

Another block. More quiet.

Phainon didn’t answer.

When they reached the courthouse steps, Mydei adjusted his bag, gave him a nod—brisk, polite. “Thanks for the walk.”

Phainon just stood there, shoulder leaning lightly against the rail. He looked like he might say something more, but didn’t. Whatever attempt he’d been making settled instead into a smile. The kind that didn’t carry much weight. The kind you wear when you’ve already decided not to push again.

“Anytime,” he said.

Mydei didn’t look back as he climbed the steps.

The door clicked shut behind them.

Mydei had barely settled at the edge of the conference table before Hephaestion tossed a file folder in front of him and leaned back with the air of someone settling into a salon chair, not a legal briefing.

“Okay,” Hephaestion said, crossing one ankle over his knee. “Before we talk about Karyon’s email dump or the source protection updates, I just want to revisit something very important.”

Mydei didn’t look up. “If you say the word bouquet, I swear to every legal code in this building—”

“I wasn’t going to,” Hephaestion said, placing a hand over his heart. “I was just going to ask if the *floral declaration of psychological warfare* is still rotting on your desk or if you finally chucked it.”

“It’s fine,” Mydei muttered, flipping the folder open. “It’s in a vase. And technically, it hasn’t wilted yet.”

“So you’re nurturing it. Incredible.”

He ignored that. “I didn’t drag you in here to discuss the state of my desk.”

“No, you dragged me in here for advice,” Hephaestion said, “which is flattering. You never ask for help unless you’re halfway to dying.”

“Halfway,” Mydei said dryly, “is generous.”

Hephaestion let that sit for a second before his eyes sharpened. “What’s going on? You’ve already filed motions to limit scope, your source protection brief is solid, and Karyon’s team’s been playing catch-up all week. You’re ahead.”

“Only barely,” Mydei said. “Aglaea’s wording in the new motion—they’re laying groundwork. You saw the phrasing around ‘mutually agreed standards of truth’? They’re trying to pivot to a narrative argument without committing to a burden shift. I need something that preempts it.”

Hephaestion frowned, and leaned in slightly. “Okay. Fair. You want counter-language?”

“Yes.”

“I’ll draft it after lunch,” he said. “But first, tell me why you looked like you’d swallowed a USB stick when I walked into your office this morning. And don’t say ‘long night.’”

Mydei’s eyes flicked up, mildly accusatory. “You’re getting nosier.”

“Occupational hazard,” Hephaestion said. “Also, you met someone during your break.”

Mydei stared. “How—”

“You came back chewing like you’d just gotten laid. Not that I’m judging, but your mouth is suspiciously quiet now, so either the sugar crash is setting in or you’re hiding something.”

Mydei sniffed. “It wasn’t a meeting. I bumped into Phainon.”

“Oh, *do* tell,” Hephaestion said, perking up like a cat spotting a fly.

“He walked me back,” Mydei said, dismissively. “And then kept asking if I was free next week.”

Hephaestion blinked. “I’m sorry—what.”

Mydei flipped a page. “He kept pushing. Monday, Friday. All very suspicious. He’s obviously plotting something. Probably planning to catch me off guard with a cross-motion or some surprise media leak. I know sabotage when I see it.”

Hephaestion just looked at him.

Then blinked. Then coughed, loudly and violently, like air itself had betrayed him.

Mydei didn’t flinch.

“You—oh my gods.” Hephaestion set his pen down, rubbed the bridge of his nose, then looked back at him like he was trying to assess for head trauma. “You really don’t see it, do you?”

“See what?”

Hephaestion inhaled. “Okay. Imagine, for a second. Just *imagine*—hypothetically—that not everything Phainon does is part of an elaborate long game to destroy your career. Is that possible?”

Mydei frowned. “No.”

“You’re hopeless.”

“Let’s get back to the case,” Mydei said, snapping the folder shut. “Before I beat you with my left shoe.”

“Say less,” Hephaestion muttered, cracking open his laptop. “But for the record, if you *ever* do realize what’s actually happening here, I want full credit. Footnote me in the acknowledgments of your future marriage license.”

“I’m blocking you on every platform.”

Hephaestion grinned. “Still worth it.”

The call came just as he was flipping through a redwell stuffed with past filings after his discussion with Hephaestion, his desk a battlefield of sticky notes and open printouts. He glanced at the screen, thumbed the green icon.

“Mr. Damaris,” he said, already shifting gears.

The journalist’s voice came through low, rushed. “Sorry to call so suddenly. I just—do you have a minute?”

He leaned back in his chair, rubbing at his temple with two fingers. “I do now. What’s going on?”

A pause. Then, “They’re backing off. The source. I think someone got to them, or maybe they’re just scared, but… I don’t know if I can count on them to hold.”

He sat up straighter. “You can count on me.”

Another silence—this one heavier.

“The press is circling. A few sites are dragging out old pieces I wrote. Someone found my father’s company, I don’t even know how. The pressure’s nonstop. I—I don’t know how to prep for this kind of thing.”

He was already jotting notes beside his keyboard, circling terms, sketching timelines. “I’ll walk you through it. We’ll prep everything. Witness conduct, question control, redirect angles. You’re not walking in cold.”

“Even if the source folds?”

“We prepare like they won’t. If they do, I have contingencies. I’ve handled worse.” He paused, quieter now. “Not by much.”

That made them laugh—just barely. It didn’t last.

“I can meet you in person,” he added. “Tomorrow or Thursday. Whatever gives you time to breathe.”

“Tomorrow. Please.”

“Done.” He hung up without ceremony, setting the phone face down on the desk, exhale held somewhere deep in his chest.

The sun dipped past the high-rise across from his window before he moved again.

He rolled up his sleeves. Set his over sugary drink down. Pulled out a fresh legal pad and started drafting. Opening lines of direct: simple, clear, plain-spoken. Next, rebuttal points. Cross anticipation. The sharpest questions first.

He wasn’t working with fear. Not exactly. It was more like preemptive shelter-building.

By nine, the light above him buzzed once, flickering.

He didn’t look up. He just flipped the page and kept writing.

The office was quiet when the journalist arrived.

They were early. It was just them, in a long coat still damp from the morning rain, standing stiffly just inside the door with a press of worry between their brows.

Mydei motioned them in with a nod. “Take a seat.”

He did, slowly, like the chair might bite. Mydei didn’t blame them. Being on the record was one thing. Being cross-examined was another.

He pulled up the outline he’d drafted late the night before, flipping through the tabs on his screen until he landed on the right structure. “We’re not practicing testimony yet. This is orientation. Think of it like… stabilization.”

“Stabilization,” he repeated, voice thin. “So it’s really that bad?”

Mydei didn’t answer that. He clicked a few lines down and adjusted the outline for tone. “You’re not on trial. You’re a witness.”

Mr. Damaris’s fingers curled slightly on the table. “Tell that to my inbox.”

He kept his eyes on the page, but he didn’t dismiss it. “I saw the articles. They won’t be admissible. And you’re not being asked to defend the story. Just the process.”

“That feels like the same thing.”

Mydei looked up at him. He’d heard those exact words before—years ago, law school, somewhere in the chaos of late-night prep and overdrawn coffee. The echo was immediate. It hit before he could brace for it.

“It feels like the same thing.”

“It’s not,” Phainon had told him. “And you’ll win it if you stop treating it like it is.”

That night had ended in an argument. That week, a podium win. He hadn’t thought about it in years.

The silence stretched too long. Mydei blinked, recalibrated. “It’s not,” he said, steady. “And you’ll get through it if you stop treating it like it is.”

The journalist exhaled a soft deprecating laugh, but their eyes were glassy. “You say that like you actually believe it.”

“I do.”

It wasn’t a lie. Not entirely.

They worked for the next hour. Question structure, tone, likely objections. He let them speak when they needed to, let them go quiet when they didn’t. The worry never left their face, but it didn’t get worse. That was a win.

After they left, Mydei sat alone at the table for a while. The room was warm, but his spine ached from how still he’d gone.

He pulled up the outline again. Re-read it. Then deleted half the questions and started over.

Witness prep wasn’t about being right. It was about being ready.

And right now, he wasn’t sure anyone was.

The city murmured outside his apartment window, soft enough that it blended into the background. Some distant car passed. A radiator clinked once. But inside, everything was still.

Mydei sat at the edge of his couch with a glass of water in hand, flipping absently through the witness prep notes he hadn't stopped revising since the journalist left. Half the pages were already marked through. A few were smudged with ink from edits he didn't remember making.

He sighed and leaned back, letting the pages rest in his lap. The cushions dipped behind his shoulders, familiar and unyielding. The water sat untouched on the side table.

At some point, when the thoughts stopped organizing themselves, he pulled open the drawer beside the couch, looking for something—he wasn't sure what. A reference maybe, or that old cross-ex template he'd scribbled half-asleep during finals.

What he found instead was a slim manila folder. He blinked at it.

It wasn't labeled, not clearly. Just a sticker on the corner, half-peeled. He thumbed it open without thinking, and inside—

A printout. Faded from years of sun and poor toner. One of the old law school debate prompts. He remembered this one—"Press Freedom and State Interests in the Age of Digital Transparency."

God, that had been a bloodbath. A blur of microphones and flash drives and Phainon two podiums over, pacing with his tie loose and his sleeves rolled, looking like he hadn't slept and somehow still smiling.

But the memory didn't stop there.

That prompt had been the last before the semester ended. There'd been an afterparty. One of those half-lit, overcrowded faculty houses where someone inevitably started passing around flat champagne and grain liquor in mislabeled bottles. He hadn't wanted to go—he hated those nights—but

Phainon had been insistent, and somehow he'd ended up with a plastic cup in his hand, the music rattling the floorboards.

He didn't even like alcohol. Still didn't.

The scene came back in slow detail. The heat of the room. The sharp scent of something too sweet on the air. Phainon in front of him, just close enough to feel it.

They'd been arguing about something trivial—case law, probably, or precedent from a jurisdiction neither of them practiced in—but it dissolved the moment Phainon leaned in, not to speak but to listen, lips parted like he might've said something but forgot. The music pulsed behind them. Mydei had turned his head just slightly—

They hadn't kissed. Not really.

But it was close enough that Mydei still remembered the taste in the air between them. The faint smell of peaches, barely clinging to Phainon's skin like something borrowed. He didn't know if it had been cologne or lip balm or someone else's breath. He'd never asked.

The next morning, Phainon had passed him in the library without blinking.

They never talked about it.

Mydei stared at the folder in his lap for a long moment. No shift in expression, no exhale.

Then he slid it shut. Placed it neatly back in the drawer and stood.

The clock read 1:07 a.m. He didn't check his phone.

When he climbed into bed, it was without a word. He didn't toss or turn. Just lay there, eyes closed, until sleep settled in like it always did—quietly, eventually, and without ceremony.

The next day, his office lights had long since dimmed to emergency mode, a gentle hush cast over the floor like the building itself was holding its breath. Mydei leaned over the conference table, jacket off, sleeves rolled, a red pen between his teeth and three stacks of legal pads spread around him like walls.

The final prep was surgical now. No room left for improvisation, no error. He'd already gone over the motions for protective scope twice with Hephaestion, who had long since collapsed onto the couch muttering curses about caffeine and burn rates. The question now was narrow framing. What disclosures would be unavoidable. What angles the court might entertain on standing.

What Phainon might pull.

He hated that it was a factor—hated even more that he knew it was. Because if anyone was going to spin the sharpest, cleanest blade possible under the guise of procedural necessity, it would be him.

Still. He wasn't preparing for trickery. He was preparing for precision. That, in the end, was always more dangerous.

By midnight, he was adjusting footnotes on a supplementary declaration, the lines on his face fixed in concentration, the silence total.

This time, he didn't sleep.

Court was packed.

Not with spectators, not this time. Just the people who actually mattered. Karyon's in-house counsel sat to the left—stone-faced, arms folded. A cluster of board attorneys loomed behind them, silent and watchful. On the back bench, a pair of media liaisons exchanged stiff nods with one of the court clerks, neither willing to sit.

The hearing was scheduled as a routine scope clarification. That was the official line. Everyone in the room knew better.

Across the aisle, Phainon stood reviewing a file. Suprisingly he had notes in hand this time, but no whispered last-minute prep with the co-counsel. Just him. Suit pressed, hair tamed back. And yet his eyes—sharp, restless—tracked each shift in the courtroom as if mapping terrain. He glanced up briefly. Met Mydei's gaze.

Mydei didn't nod. Didn't look away either.

The clerk called the session to order.

Judge Antheia Markos, known for running a tight docket, adjusted her glasses and opened briskly. "We're here to finalize witness scope ahead of testimonial scheduling. I've reviewed the filings on both sides. Counsel for Letois Media, you may begin."

Mydei rose. "Thank you, Your Honor." He didn't waste time with preamble. "We're asking for confirmation of our scope parameters regarding the journalist's testimony, in particular the limits surrounding protected source identity and the editorial timeline in question." His tone stayed even. "Per existing state privilege doctrine—codified under Eleventh District precedent, see *Maris v. Collier Press*—we're asserting that the core of the journalist's communications remains privileged, with testimony limited to article development practices and non-confidential internal reviews."

He paused, let the judge absorb it.

"It's a clean boundary. We're not asserting blanket immunity. We're delineating what qualifies as non-material versus what violates established protections."

Judge Markos nodded. "Understood. Counsel for the plaintiff?"

Phainon rose, stepping forward with a courtesy nod. "We're not seeking to pierce privilege," he started with. "We're submitting a supplemental motion to clarify an inconsistency in their original scope brief." He held up a page—single sheet, neatly clipped. "Specifically, Footnote Nine, which contains a reference to the timeline for editorial approval. That timeline appears inconsistent with internal timestamps disclosed in preliminary exhibits. If

the witness affirms one over the other, the question becomes whether their communications during that disputed timeframe are material—not to source identity, but to testimonial consistency."

He handed the page to the clerk. "We've attached a brief appendix identifying three metadata entries that raise the issue."

Judge Markos frowned, flipping through the addendum. "This is new material."

"Supplemental, Your Honor. No new claims—just a clarification request."

She turned to Mydei. "Counsel?"

Mydei had already reviewed the footnote in his head. He remembered writing it. It had been a shorthand reference—useful for establishing chronology, but not vital. Not until now. He stood, hands steady as he adjusted the mic.

"We're prepared to offer a stipulation on the approval window," he said. "The exhibit references are authentic, but the editorial delay was procedural—backlog, not intent. We're willing to amend Footnote Nine to reflect that distinction."

"No objection to the clarification?" the judge asked.

"Not to the clarification," Mydei said. Then, calmly: "But I'll note that the metadata cited, while accurate, was cherry-picked. It omits the concurrent receipt of an anonymized tip logged through encrypted channels. If counsel for the plaintiff is intending to suggest testimonial inconsistency, we'd ask that the court consider the full chain of submissions—not just the three that support selective doubt."

Phainon's expression didn't change. He stepped forward again. "We'd welcome a full chain review, if opposing counsel is amenable to a shared timeline reconciliation. We're not accusing the journalist of inconsistency—we're trying to ensure the scope allows for clarification without implicating protected exchanges."

Mydei narrowed his eyes. The phrasing was too precise. It gave the appearance of pressure without actually applying it. That was the problem.

He turned to Judge Markos. “We’ll accept a mutual reconciliation process. Limited in scope to timestamped editorial exchanges. But any suggestion that it extend to anonymized material, or requires unmasking the identity behind the encrypted tip, would exceed privilege boundaries and be opposed in full.”

“Agreed,” the judge said, nodding. “I’m not ordering exposure of anonymous sources today. This hearing’s purpose is to define testimonial guardrails, not test them.”

But Mydei’s mind stayed two steps ahead.

Because Phainon could have pushed. He could’ve submitted an interrogatory that cornered the journalist. He could’ve filed a broader motion to compel. He could’ve cited corporate leak protocols or used cross-reference analysis from Karyon’s internal systems to pin the whistleblower’s trail. There were at least three technical paths forward, and Phainon knew them. So why didn’t he take them?

Mydei looked over, slightly stunned. Phainon had returned to his seat. His posture was easy, almost lazy. But his eyes were on him again.

He knew.

The judge turned back to her notes. “I’ll enter a modified scope order. Footnote Nine is amended for the record. A joint reconciliation of editorial timeline entries will be permitted—confined to material dates, not source content. Source protection remains intact unless compelling interest is demonstrated, which I do not see here.”

She banged the gavel lightly. “This hearing is adjourned.”

The room exhaled as one. Chairs shifted. Pages rustled. Mydei gathered his file slowly.

When he stood, Phainon had already moved to the aisle. Not lingering but close enough.

As Mydei passed him, he paused—barely a breath's worth of delay—and said, without turning: "You're not nearly as ruthless as you pretend."

Phainon didn't flinch. His voice was quiet, almost amused. "And you're not nearly as oblivious as you act."

Mydei kept walking. He didn't look back. But his grip tightened around the file in his hand, and for the first time since the motion hit the docket, his pulse quickened.

Not from annoyance or anger.

From the restraint.

The elevator was too slow.

Mydei adjusted the folder beneath his arm—fresh notes from a second round of witness prep, barely annotated yet—and tapped his knuckles once against the brushed steel wall. The court wouldn't issue the written order until at least tomorrow, maybe longer. Until then, it was limbo. Controlled, procedural limbo. And he hated it.

The doors opened on the twenty-fourth. Ptolemy was waiting there, half-lost in a tangle of papers and a too-warm scarf looped three times around his neck despite the office building's overzealous central heating.

"Mydei!" he beamed, stepping back to let him pass. "I heard you were in court this morning—one of the scope disputes, wasn't it? The source protection thing?"

Mydei nodded. "Yes. Karyon's team raised a motion."

"And did they get obliterated?" Ptolemy's tone was light, but his eyes flicked briefly to the folder in Mydei's hands.

“No. But they didn’t win either.” He stepped out, matching Ptolemy’s pace down the corridor. “Partial modification granted. Witness is still protected.”

Ptolemy let out a low, appreciative whistle. “Tactical restraint. Must’ve been a sight.” He paused. “Was it Phainon?”

Mydei glanced over. “It was.”

“Ah.” A beat passed. “He’s good. You’re better.”

Mydei didn’t answer.

They reached the corner where the hallway split. Ptolemy shifted the weight of the papers in his arms and offered a half-smile.

“You’ve got that look,” he said. “Like you’re already back in it.”

“I am.”

“Well,” Ptolemy shrugged, “if you need a second pair of eyes on anything —no pressure, obviously—but I’m around. Just say the word.”

“Thanks,” Mydei said quietly. “I’ll let you know.”

And with that, they parted.

Mydei kept the door half-shut when he returned to the office. Not quite closed, not quite open—just enough to dissuade anyone who didn’t already know him from walking in.

The lights overhead were dimmer than usual, or maybe his eyes just hadn’t adjusted yet. A half-empty folder lay on the desk beside his keyboard, court orders clipped neatly on top. He’d already summarized the decision for the firm’s internal memo—two paragraphs, even-toned, stripped of anything that could read as opinion.

Now he was halfway through a follow-up note to the journalist. Clarifying what they were and weren’t obligated to hand over, how narrow the

clarification was, how solid the protections remained. He phrased everything carefully, just in case.

A knock came. Not loud—just a couple of taps. He didn't even glance up.

"Door's open."

It wasn't. Not really. But Hephaestion stepped in anyway, dressed like someone who hadn't had a serious morning since the second year of law school.

"So," he said, dropping into the guest chair without being asked, "you won?"

Mydei didn't pause his typing. "We didn't lose."

"That's what winning sounds like when you've been emotionally compromised."

Mydei flicked him a dry look. "Do you want the post-mortem or not?"

Hephaestion leaned back, crossing one ankle over the other. "Nah. Just wanted to see if you'd started spiraling yet."

"I'm drafting a protective order summary. That's not spiraling."

"That's what spiraling looks like for you."

A quiet settled. Just the tapping of keys and sound of traffic outside the windows. Hephaestion's gaze drifted around the room, landing on the corner of the desk—an empty mug, long gone cold. The bouquet next to it had wilted, petals sagging in on themselves like they'd overheard too much and finally gave up. Mydei hadn't thrown them out. Not out of sentiment, just… forgetfulness. He told himself that, anyway.

Hephaestion didn't say anything about them. Not directly.

Instead, he asked, "Did he say anything after?"

Mydei didn’t look away from the screen. “Phainon?”

There was a brief pause, like he was checking if that name would do anything to him. It didn’t. Not aloud, anyway.

He shook his head. “Not a word.”

Hephaestion sounded almost in awe. “That’s the loudest I’ve ever seen him be.”

Mydei stopped typing.

Just for a half-beat. A space between thoughts where his fingers didn’t move and his eyes that didn’t shift.

He didn’t respond.

He just resumed typing—slower, like each keystroke had to be considered twice.

The final court order had been issued that morning—clean, typed, and emailed out to every party. But Mydei was at the courthouse anyway.

He could have just forwarded the PDF to the comms liaison and let it die in the inbox like everything else, but Kremnos Stratton preferred hard copies for case files. That meant someone had to walk the damn thing over, request the certified version, and make sure the clerk didn’t miss a timestamp or initial. And since Hephaestion was neck-deep in source documentation—and Mydei didn’t entirely trust the junior assigned to records—he did it himself.

It was quieter than it had been during the hearing. No reporters now. No murmuring board reps or tight-lipped associates in dark suits pretending not to glance across the aisle. Just the low thrum of the building’s air system and the steady click of shoes against marble.

He thanked the clerk, took the stamped order in a crisp envelope, and turned toward the exit—and paused when he saw someone already waiting near the staircase.

Phainon.

He had one hand in his coat pocket and the other wrapped around a paper cup, some local café's logo half-faded from condensation. He looked up at the sound of footsteps and blinked.

"Oh," he said, like he hadn't been standing there for long. "Hey."

Mydei nodded. "You here for the order too?"

"Mm." Phainon lifted the envelope in his hand. "Didn't have to be, but figured I might as well grab the official copy. You know how Aglea is with optics."

Mydei snorted faintly. "I do."

They didn't plan to fall into step, but they did anyway—moving through the long, cooled halls toward the double doors. Their footsteps echoed slightly.

For a moment, neither said anything. The envelope in Mydei's hand felt heavier than it should have.

"You read it yet?" Phainon asked finally, keeping his tone light.

Mydei nodded. "Straightforward enough. The date range got trimmed by two weeks, and the metadata request was denied."

A beat.

"I noticed," Phainon said. "Nice clause about cross-referencing protections. That had your handwriting all over it."

Mydei gave a quiet sound of acknowledgment. "I almost cut it. Thought the judge would toss it."

“She almost did.” Phainon smiled, not looking at him. “But she didn’t.”

The courthouse doors hissed open ahead of them, letting in the early afternoon air—warmer than expected, the city holding onto the tail-end of spring before it cracked fully into heat. They stepped out, side by side.

Mydei adjusted the strap of his briefcase. “You think she split the ruling to avoid setting precedent?”

“Maybe,” Phainon said. “Or maybe she just liked the way you said ‘procedural necessity.’”

Mydei rolled his eyes. “Don’t be smug.”

“I’m never smug,” Phainon said, with a perfectly straight face.

They reached the steps. Below them, the courthouse plaza stretched wide, mostly empty, except for a few assistants and runners hurrying in and out with folders tucked under their arms.

“So,” Phainon said. “Big post-case celebration back at Kremnos?”

“Celebration?” Mydei glanced at him. “No one wins these kinds of hearings.”

“True. But you didn’t lose.”

Mydei said nothing to that. After a few steps, he muttered, “That line’s getting some mileage this week.”

“Because it’s true,” Phainon said, sipping from his cup. “Sometimes that’s the only kind of win we get.”

They walked a bit more. Not fast. Not slow. Just enough to not draw attention.

Phainon spoke again, after a pause. “Your witness held up. Despite the pressure.”

“She’s tougher than people think.”

“Or maybe she just trusts her counsel.”

That earned him a glance.

Phainon didn’t look away. “She should.”

The breeze picked up, catching the hem of Mydei’s coat. He didn’t respond, and Phainon didn’t push. They just walked, side by side, toward the next block—wherever that led.

Neither of them said goodbye when they reached the corner. Mydei had already turned to leave.

The walk had ended. They’d said everything that needed saying—enough about the case, enough silence to carry what they weren’t saying—and he was half a block down when he heard it.

“Wait—!”

It wasn’t the volume that stopped him. It was the tone—half-startled, half-panicked, like it had slipped out without permission. Mydei turned, one brow lifting.

Phainon stood at the corner still, like his legs had forgotten how to move. His hand was halfway raised, then dropped quickly to his side. He looked like he regretted everything that had ever happened, including—but not limited to—being born.

“…What?” Mydei asked, skeptical.

Phainon coughed.

Actually *coughed*.

“Just—I meant to ask—” He paused, ran a hand through his hair, then winced like he’d just made it worse. “You’re not too busy tonight, are you?”

Mydei stared at him.

“Because I was thinking,” Phainon said, all in one breath now, “maybe we could—not about court, obviously, or actually maybe yes a little because we’re terrible at small talk—but also just. Not at the courthouse. Somewhere else. With food. Together.”

Mydei blinked. “Was that supposed to be a sentence?”

Phainon cleared his throat again. “Dinner. I’m asking if you want dinner. With me. As a date.”

Silence.

A full beat.

Phainon smiled nervously. “You don’t have to say yes. I mean, you can, it would be legally sound, but—”

“Phainon,” Mydei said, very slowly, “are you having an episode?”

Phainon opened his mouth, then closed it. “Possibly.”

He stood there, visibly holding himself together with nothing but residual dignity and espresso. And somehow, that’s when it hit Mydei—not with drama or fanfare, just a quiet shift.

Oh.

Oh.

He wasn’t sure what did it. The rambling? The crooked way Phainon’s tie had come undone at the end of their walk? The fact that this man had just gone head-to-head with him in a federal courthouse effortlessly and was now—right here—too flustered to form a complete sentence?

It was absurd.

It was unfair.

It was sort of… endearing.

And that was the problem.

Mydei didn’t say anything right away.

Phainon, in the meantime, looked like he was living an entire lifetime in the span of five seconds. His smile twitched. “Right. Okay. That’s fine. I’ll just —assume that’s a no. Or a very elegant version of a no. And I will walk off this curb with dignity intact—”

“Phainon.”

Phainon froze.

Mydei’s voice wasn’t amused. Or annoyed. Or even smug.

It was soft.

“You didn’t ask if I was busy tomorrow.”

Phainon blinked. “Wait, are you—”

“I didn’t say yes,” Mydei said. “But I also didn’t say no.”

There was the faintest curve at the edge of his mouth now. Not a smile—yet. But close.

Phainon’s heart skipped so hard it could’ve been cited as a workplace hazard. “So… that’s a maybe?”

“Conditional. Based on where you plan to take me. And if you’re less of a wreck by then.”

“Define wreck,” Phainon said, trying to sound cool again and failing completely.

Mydei turned, started walking away again. “You just asked your legal rival to dinner while looking like you were about to faint.”

Phainon watched him go, stunned—and then a few paces in, Mydei glanced back over his shoulder.

“Seven. Tomorrow.”

Then he was gone.

And Phainon, still at the corner, just quietly whispered to himself:

“…Holy shit.”

Hephaestion didn’t even look up from the folder he was flipping through when Mydei stepped into the office.

“So. You’re going.”

Mydei paused mid-step. “Going where.”

Hephaestion finally looked at him. “Oh come on.”

He closed the folder with unnecessary drama and leaned back in his chair, arms crossed, like he’d been waiting to deliver this monologue since law school.

“Do you want me to say it?” he asked. “Or do you want the dignity of saying it yourself.”

“There’s nothing to say,” Mydei said coolly, heading to his desk.

“Right. Because people definitely come back from court order pickups looking like they’ve just been *personally invited* to lose their minds.”

Mydei sat, opened his laptop, and willed himself to type something, anything, even one sentence of the post-court update he’d meant to finish.

Nothing came out.

Hephaestion grinned. “So what did he do? Flirt with case law? Whisper sweet jurisdictional threats?”

“He asked me out,” Mydei muttered.

Hephaestion sat up. “*What.*”

“Dinner. Tomorrow.” He adjusted his screen. “He was flustered. I think he blacked out halfway through it.”

Hephaestion looked like Christmas had come early.

“I knew it,” he said, smug. “I knew it since he left that note before the injunction hearing. The one with the stupid smiley face.”

Mydei blinked. “That wasn’t a threat?”

“Oh my god.”

Hephaestion leaned across the desk, grinning like a man who had been deeply vindicated.

“You’re telling me your nemesis—who you’ve been half-arguing, half-eye-fucking across courtrooms for *years*—confessed actual feelings, and you’re just. Sitting here. Typing?”

“I’m not typing,” Mydei said sharply.

Hephaestion made a noise like he’d just won an internal office pool. “You’re spiraling.”

“I’m not.”

“You’re *spiraling*,” Hephaestion said with delight. “God, this is better than the time I found out Phainon once quoted Euripides in a deposition. You’re literally malfunctioning.”

Mydei didn’t reply. He just stared at the blank screen.

Because, yes, his professional rival—the one who'd driven him insane since they were first-year debate partners, the one who always showed up exactly when he didn't need him to—had not only liked him, but apparently had for *some time* it seems.

That was not part of the plan.

He wasn't even sure there was a plan anymore.

"You gonna go?" Hephaestion asked, already knowing the answer.

Mydei didn't look up. "I said yes."

Hephaestion stood with a satisfied nod, like his work here was done. "Good. Wear something hot."

The door clicked shut behind him.

Mydei stared at the screen a second longer. Then glanced at the time. Then at the coat rack. Then slowly ran a hand down his face.

He wasn't panicking.

He was just… thinking extremely hard. About logistics. And expectations. And how in the name of all that was logical he was supposed to dress for a date with the man who once subpoenaed his inbox and smiled while doing it.

He didn't know what he was going to wear.

But he knew it mattered.

And he couldn't, for the life of him, remember how to breathe normally.

End Notes

Yeah this definitely has a few inaccuracies so feel free to point them out if you'd like and when I have free time I'll change it😍👍.

Anyway how did we feel abt this? My inner nerd came out with this one. By the journalist part though, it was a bit rushed cause my original goal of 10k or less was starting to get surpassed (Hence why so many timeskips after that😭)

Anyway, thanks for reading <333

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